

Seawall height in Key West

The elevation your city requires, the datum it is measured in, and the section of code that says so.

KEY WEST • MONROE COUNTY

No minimum set in local code

Key West's Code of Ordinances sets no minimum or maximum seawall top elevation in any datum. The city's land development rules discourage vertical seawalls altogether: shoreline hardening is allowed only when erosion is a critical peril and vegetation has failed, and riprap comes first. Any wall height is set by your engineer and your permits.

The detail

NO FIXED ELEVATION	Key West Code Sec. 110-182 (Shoreline vegetation and stability) controls shoreline hardening and states no seawall top elevation in NAVD88, NGVD29 or any other datum.
WHEN HARDENING IS ALLOWED	Riprap, bulkheads or similar devices are not allowed unless erosion constitutes a critical peril to upland property and vegetation has failed to stabilize the shoreline. Riprap shall be the first alternative. Sec. 110-182(c).
VERTICAL WALLS DISCOURAGED	Such shoreline hardening structures shall generally not be vertical seawalls or bulkheads, and pervious interlocking systems, filter mats and similar methods are to be used instead of vertical walls whenever feasible. Sec. 110-182(c) and (c)(2).
LOCATION	The structure may not sit waterward of the mean high water line unless shown to be in the public interest, and must first be approved by the other public agencies with jurisdiction. Sec. 110-182(c)(3) and (c)(4).
REVEGETATION	The design must include a program of shoreline vegetation or revegetation. Sec. 110-182(c)(5).
PERMIT	Bulkheads, piers and docks along the shoreline are installed under permit from the building official. Sec. 118-361.
FLOOD ZONES	The floodplain chapter lists bulkheads and seawalls among other development regulated in flood hazard areas. Sec. 34-139.

Where this comes from: City of Key West Code of Ordinances, Subpart B Land Development Regulations, Sec. 110-182 (Shoreline vegetation and stability); also Sec. 118-361 and Sec. 34-139; online version Aug 21, 2026

Verified: 2026-10. Rules change — check the date above against today.

Before you call a contractor

1 Know your datum

A height means nothing without the datum it is measured from. NAVD88 and MLW are different reference points and the same wall gives different numbers in each. Ask which one any quoted elevation refers to.

2 Get the existing elevation surveyed

You cannot tell whether a wall meets the requirement by looking at it. A surveyor shooting the top of the cap settles it in an hour.

3 Ask what triggers the requirement

Most cities only apply the minimum to new walls or to substantial repair. What counts as substantial is defined differently in each city, and it is usually a percentage of length or of cost.

4 Ask about building higher now

Several cities require a wall built below the final figure to be engineered so it can be raised later. Doing it once is cheaper than doing it twice.